

Being and Essence

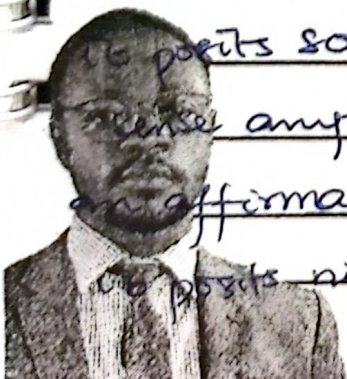
Chapter One.

Introduction / Prologue

Aquinas posited that there is an ignorance arising from the terms being and essence. This ignorance leads to great errors that influence final conclusions. However, to avoid this error there is need to resolve the difficulties surrounding the explanation of the terms "being" and "essence" as well as clarifying how they relate with logical intentions, of genus, species and difference.

Chapter One.

There are two senses of being; first, being signifying that which is divided into ten categories and second, being signifying the truth of propositions. In the first sense, nothing can be called a being unless it posits something in reality, whereas in the second sense anything can be called a being about which an affirmative proposition can be formed, even if it posits nothing in reality.



The meaning of essence is taken from the first sense, this is because being in the first sense signifies the essence of a thing. Essence therefore means something common to all natures through which various beings are placed in various genera and species, as humanity is the essence of man. Essence is also called quiddity, because essence is what is signified by the definition. It is also called form, since the certitude of everything is through its form. Essence is called nature since it signifies the essence of a thing as it is ordered to the proper operation of the thing.

Essence like being are only in substances and only in a certain way for accidents. Essence is in both simple and composite substances but it is truer and in a more noble manner in simple substance, for instance God, because the simple substances are the cause of the composite ones.

Chapter 2

Composite substances consist of matter and form, (soul & body) however, we cannot say that either of them is the essence of a thing. Matter is not a principle of cognition nor is anything determined according to genus using the matter, therefore matter cannot be said of essence alone since essence makes a thing knowable and places them in species and genus.

Form on the other hand is not the essence of composite thing since the definition of natural substance contains both form and also matter. Aquinas therefore posited that essence clearly comprises both matter and form in composite substances.

Aquinas posited that essence is neither particular alone or universal alone. For him matter is not a principle of individuation; Only signate matter is the principle of individuation. Signate matter is in the definition of specific definition like Socrates. There is also non-signate matter which is in the definition of a man. Therefore, essence of man and essence of Socrates differ only in signate and non signate. He also made a similar distinction between genus and species, whereby the genus signify the ^{whole} essence of the species, although each of the species have their ^{individual} own essence. (Man is the universal, which contains essence of species like Socrates, Plato, though the species also

Chapter 3.

Aquinas explores the relationship between essence and the logical intention (categories) of genus, species and difference. He argued that we cannot say that the intention of species is appropriate to the essence in a certain way. For him essence is signified as a whole not as a mere part of a thing.

He stated that essence can be understood in three ways, first; essence considered according to its proper notion (absolute consideration). Here nothing ^{is true of essence} pertains to it except what pertains to it, other things are attributed to it falsely. In the second consideration, the essence is considered as it exists in things (in individuals). This has a double existence, it exists as singulars on the one hand and in the soul on the other hand.

He posited that the notion of species and genus arise in the third consideration of the essence, in which the essence is considered as intellect. Although essence understood as intellect has the notion of a universal in relation to outside the soul

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Chapter 4.

Aquinas began to discuss separated substances, such as the soul and the intelligences. These separated substances are different from the first cause, however he noted that these substances are wholly without matter as some scholars tried to prove. Aquinas posited that though they do not have matter, that they have form and essence, where form is taken from simple quiddity.

He argued that, matter is dependent on form, but form is not dependent on matter, hence form can exist without matter. Form from intelligences are forms which exist without matter and which are closest to first principle.

He also identified a distinction b/w ^{the essence of} composite substances and simple substances. firstly, the essence of composite substances embrace form and matter, while that of simple substances is form alone, secondly, the essence of composite substances can be signified as a whole or as a part, while the essence of simple substances cannot be signified as except as a whole. Finally, since essence of composite substances are received in designate matter, they can be multiplied according to the divisions of matter. this kind of multiplication cannot occur in simple substances.

Aquinas argued that the separated substances although they are form alone without matter, they are not in every way simple, because they are not pure act. For him, they have an admixture of potency. He posited that the intelligences are both form and existence. Their essence or form is one thing and their existence is another thing. He concluded by positing that everything which is not existence alone, has a cause of ^{its} existence. Therefore, since intelligences are form and existence, they have the cause of existence from the first cause of being, which is existence alone, and this first cause is God.

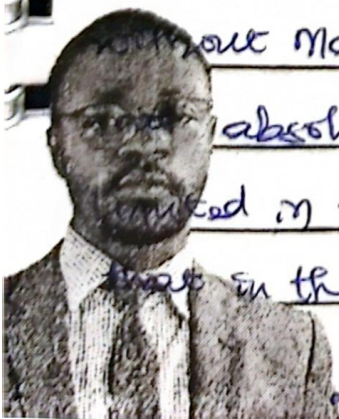
He also made a distinction of the separate substances by grading their potency and act, in how close they are to the first cause. Things which are closer have more act and less potency. For him, below God, ^{and} the angels sit the human soul which is the lowest of intellectual substances, it has more potency. However it is above other material beings which are closest to matter.

Chapter 5.

Aquinas in this chapter explains how essence is found in various kinds of things. For him, there are three ways in which substances may have an essence.

(1) 1st: is the way God has essence. - He posited that God's essence is identical with his existence. He is pure existence. Also, he argued that God is not in a genus, because ~~he does not~~ has many members, but God is one and unique. He argued against philosophers who posited that God is a universal being. For him God is not existence in general but a pure and distinct existence. If he is universal, he would be divided and combined with other things which is not possible. He also posited that though God is existence alone, he is not lacking in any perfections and nobilities.

(2) The Second way; essence as found in created intellectual substances: Here existence of the intellectual substance is different from its essence, although the essence is without matter. Aquinas noted that their existence is absolute but received, as such they are finite and limited in their capacity of receiving nature. He noted that in these substances we do not find a multitude
Note - Their existence is received from God, they are not self-existent.



of individuals in one species, therefore each Intelligence is a unique species in its own.

(5) Third way; Essence found in substances composed of matter and form: Here existence is both received and limited because they receive existence from God. He noted that these substances are finite both in a superior way and an inferior way because of the division of signate matter, and multiplication of individuals in one species.

Chapter 8

Having explained earlier, essences of substances, Aquinas tries to explain also that there are essences in accidents. He argued that accidents have essence in the same way or which they have definitions, therefore, since they have incomplete definitions, meaning that they cannot be defined unless we put a subject in their definition; their essences is incomplete. This means that, just as accidents are a being only in a certain sense, so too does it have essence only in a certain sense.

Aquinas noted that accidents relate to their subject in different ways; for him since the parts of the substance are matter and form, some accidents are consequence of the form while some are consequence of the matter. Among accidents which are consequence of the form are the intellectual soul. He noted also that accidents which are consequence of matter such as blackness still communicates with the form.

Aquinas noted that some accidents are caused by the essential principles of a thing according to its perfect act, such as heat in fire, while other accidents are the results of an aptitude in the substance, which arises from an external agent.

Conclusion